THE **ARTISTS**

Stepping into Stardom

'***Lokah* has made my dreams** feel bigger," says actress Kalyani Priyadarshan while reflecting on the defining film of her career. The 2025 film, in which she played a vampire superheroine, was an ingenious, funny and thrilling piece of work that went on to become Malayalam cinema's highest grosser. It also opened doors for Kalyani beyond Kerala. "I find myself in rooms with people that I have admired for years. There are more doors opening, which didn't happen before," she says. "I need to work even harder to make the most of these opportunities."

Daughter of renowned filmmaker Priyadarshan, Kalyani's is a more long-winded route to success. An early turning point in that journey, she says, was a late-night conversation with her father where she told him she wanted to become an actor. "I was shaking, because he never wanted me or my brother to work in films. He knows how gruelling the life is. He, in turn, said, 'I will support you in whatever you want to do'."

With *Lokah*'s success comes a sense of responsibility about the choices she makes. "When you do something successful, people offer you more of the same. I have always been an actor who wants to keep surprising people," she says. "I believe that for you to be a great actor or grow as one, you should be able to do everything." And rather than judging the morality of the parts, she scrutinises the quality of the stories and the connection she is able to forge with them. "I have always found it easy to say 'No' to good opportunities to make room for the right ones," she says.

Meanwhile, the ripple effects of *Lokah* continue to be felt across Indian cinema. Action heroines have got top billing in Samantha-starring Telugu entertainer *Maa Inti Bangaaram* and Tamil film *Blast*. Kalyani, though, would love for gender to not be the criterion to measure a film's worth. "I hope we move away from thinking female-led films as a separate category. A great story is a great story," she says. And her advice to other women? "Never let success get to your head and failure to your heart. Highs and lows cannot dictate who you are." ■

— Suhani Singh

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Kalyani anchored *Lokah Chapter 1: Chandra*, Malayalam cinema's highest-grossing film (over Rs 300 crore), proving women-centred titles can be pan-India phenomena too

INSPIRATION

Veteran Malayalam actress Urvashi is Kalyani's biggest inspiration. "Urvashi ma'am can make you laugh, then break your heart in the next scene. I have aspired to not be limited to one kind of role because of her. She is proof that actresses don't have a shelf life"